

Employment and Economic Self-Sufficiency: 2015 National Goals for Research, Policy, and Practice

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Abstract

Employment in general workforce and economic self-sufficiency continue to be the exceptions for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), rather than the norm. Research, policy, and practice can and should play a coordinated role in solving this problem. This article summarizes the methods used and the consensus-based national goals identified to guide the direction of the field that were developed by experts in the field. A discussion of the implications of the findings is also provided, including the need for advocacy to advance the goals.

Key Words: *intellectual and developmental disabilities; IDD; employment; national goals*

Major advancements in employment supports and services have been achieved since the introduction of supported employment in the Developmental Disabilities Act of 1984 and the Rehabilitation Act Amendments of 1986. Practices such as supported and customized employment, career planning and assessment, natural support development, and business engagement have been tested and honed to show that people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), including those with the most extensive support needs, can work with or without supports in individual jobs in the community (Becker & Drake, 2003; Callahan, Shumpert, & Condon, 2009; Griffin, Hammis, Geary, & Molly, 2008; Kluesner, Taylor, & Bordieri, 2005). Recent research also indicates that people with IDD have a preference for employment in the community (Butterworth, Hiersteiner, Engler, Bershadsky, & Bradley, 2015; Migliore, Grossi, Mank, & Rogan, 2008), regardless of the intensity of their support needs (Migliore et al., 2008).

Despite these advancements and the demand, today, only 15% of people receiving services from state IDD agencies worked in integrated employment including both individual and group supported employment, with 10% working in

individual competitive or supported jobs (Bradley, Bershadsky, Giordano, Hiersteiner, Kennedy-Lizotte, & Butterworth, 2015; Butterworth et al., 2015). For youth and young adults, only 6% of individuals with IDD ages 16–21 and 17% of individuals with IDD ages 22–30 are working in integrated employment (Butterworth, Migliore, Sulewski, & Zalewska, 2014).

These challenges have been recognized and formal disability support systems are responding or being challenged to more effectively facilitate individual employment outcomes and embrace employment as a priority for people with IDD. At the federal level, a more consistent set of values appear to be coming into focus. Through the Workforce Innovation and Opportunities Act (WIOA) of 2014, the 2011 Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services (CMS) guidance on integrated employment and related 2014 integrated setting rule, the U.S. Department of Justice's broader enforcement of the Olmstead decision to include employment services and a number of other federal employment initiatives, the federal government appears committed to affirm the importance of employment and one's right to receive employment supports in the community.

Additionally, nearly every state across the country has some form of Employment First initiative and 60% have a formal state policy or directive (APSE, 2014) that strives to establish clear guiding principles, practices, and priorities to more effectively facilitate employment by way of state service systems (APSE, 2014; Moseley 2009).

As the field enters this new Employment First era of employment opportunities and supports, a framework is needed to guide the direction of policy, practice, and research and focus attention, resources, and energy on making employment and economic self-sufficiency a reality for more people with IDD. The purpose of this article is to present the national goals that are most likely to advance this cause.

Method

At the National Goals 2015 Conference in Washington, DC, members of the employment and economic self-sufficiency strand team utilized a three-step process to develop employment and economic self-sufficiency goals. The strand leadership team first identified and invited a panel of established and emerging leaders with expertise in employment-related research, policy, and practice to participate in the goal development process. To prepare panelists for participation, each was provided, in advance of the conference, an annotated bibliography of 17 influential employment-related research peer-reviewed journal articles and a book chapter summarizing the policy, practice, and research in employment for people with IDD, titled, *Employment for People With IDD: What Do We Know and Where Are We Going?* (Nord et al., in press).

Upon assembling at the National Goals 2015 Conference, the employment and economic self-sufficiency strand participants engaged in an information gathering and idea generation process. This included an opening presentation to frame what is known about employment for people with IDD and to spark conversation. It also included a 5½ hour facilitated discussion to identify and capture (a) big debates and points of contention in the field of employment for people with IDD, (b) methodological challenges to researching employment and economic self-sufficiency, (c) unanswered questions of most importance to advance employment and economic self-sufficiency for people with IDD, and (d) the next big ideas and paradigm shifts that need to occur to facilitate better outcomes for people with IDD.

The data collected from the facilitated discussion process was synthesized to capture overarching themes. On day two, these themes were presented, discussed, and gaps were identified and thematically ordered by participants. Upon agreement of the themes, specific research questions that would enable the overarching themes to be addressed were developed, debated, and revised until consensus was reached among the strand participants.

National Goals and Rationale

The minimal improvement and stagnation of employment supports and outcomes for people with IDD is decades old (Butterworth, Winsor, et al., 2015) and rooted in, among other things, a long history of deficits-based service models and the presumed incompetence of the population. With the renewed focus and momentum to advance employment for people with IDD a clear vision is needed to guide the future of research, practice, and policy; as such, seven national goals, described next, were identified as critical to advance and improve employment and economic self-sufficiency of people with IDD.

1. *Research to understand and improve the effectiveness of public service systems to facilitate employment and to advance systems changes that most effectively bolster employment and decrease reliance on public benefits.*

For many people with IDD, public service systems play a vital role in gaining access to formal employment and related support services. Public systems of education, Medicaid Home and Community-Based Services Long-Term Services and Supports, and Vocational Rehabilitation serve many people with IDD, yet their outcomes are highly variable across systems and states. In addition, these systems have experienced increased internal and external pressures to adapt to the emerging Employment First landscape. Public service systems are being pushed to shift and align values; adopt collaborative, interagency practices that lead to more seamless employment supports; adopt consistent expectations of working-age people with IDD; and increase the system capacity to support individual employment in the community.

In this time of mixed outcomes and robust systems change, there is much to learn to ensure investments of money, personnel, and time are

being spent in ways that most effectively and efficiently achieve better outcomes. The purpose of this national goal is to highlight this need and motivate the research community to advance what is known about what makes public service systems effective and how best to deploy employment systems change. To address this goal, specific research questions may include:

- a. *How do individual factors, such as social networks, interact with formal support systems to achieve employment outcomes?*
 - b. *What are effective ways to braid employment and community integration supports to enhance employment outcomes and employment choices?*
 - c. *What are critical components of successful employment systems change to transform states and support organizations to provide employment supports?*
 - d. *What professional support practices at the individual and system level predict quality employment outcomes?*
 - e. *How can existing systems better facilitate and support nontraditional assistance (e.g., self-directed, community member, natural, and informal supports)?*
2. ***Improve employment supports and interventions by researching new and innovative practices, strategies, tools, and technologies; and develop evidence-based strategies for operationalizing implementation and scale-up of interventions.***

Innovative interventions have been a core feature of the supported employment movement since its inception. This culture of innovation must continue by improving what exists today and creating new solutions to the employment challenges people with IDD face. To support this notion, policy makers, practitioners, and researchers must invest in the development and testing of innovative solutions that lead to quality individual employment in the community.

This national goal recognizes the importance of taking a wide view regarding interventions. Rather than identifying the need of a single type of intervention, such as support models or technology, this goal intends to challenge the field to think broader. A sampling of areas where interventions are needed include models of employment support, technologies to facilitate employment, career development and advancement approaches, and informal support strategies. Addi-

tionally, interventions targeting different audiences are needed, such as youth and adults with IDD, family members, guardians, employers, community members, support professionals, and so on.

To ensure that new and existing developments are widely available, it is also necessary for greater attention and effort to be given to implementation and scale-up. As a field dedicated to advancing employment, it is unacceptable for effective interventions to be accessible to only narrow groups of people with IDD. Greater energy must be given to expanding the reach of these interventions for people with IDD and professionals within the formal disability systems as well as people with IDD and their networks outside of the formal systems. With a focus on quality implementation and expansion of access of intervention more people with IDD will be able to achieve the employment outcomes they desire.

3. ***Research effective strategies, policies, and environmental conditions that support individuals to choose and plan careers that foster economic advancement and community membership across the lifespan.***

Today, many people with IDD have multiple types of employment services and support from which to choose. For example, individual employment supports for jobs in the general labor market or self-employment, group-based supports for a job in the community, and facility-based supports for a job in more segregated setting each yield different financial, social, and integration outcomes. It is also known that many people with IDD opt out of the general labor market by choosing more restrictive services. To more effectively facilitate a life in the community and in the regular workforce it is necessary to gain clarity as to why people with IDD opt into the general labor market. Specific research questions that may facilitate achieving this goal include:

- a. *What are effective policies and system practices that guide and support people with IDD into the workforce and out of poverty?*
 - b. *What are best practices to engage people with IDD and their family members to facilitate choosing competitive employment as a priority life outcome?*
4. ***Research to understand, develop, harness, and enhance one's social capital and community relationships to build effective networks in***

traditional and nontraditional supports to facilitate employment and career advancement that leads to economic self-sufficiency.

There is growing recognition in the employment supports field that one's social capital and community connectedness are valuable resources that cannot be replicated by a service system. Social networks have enhanced formal support services by acting as a personal asset that can be tapped to identify and develop new work opportunities, to provide ongoing job retention support and assistance, and to develop career pathways. Additionally, many people with IDD do not access formal supports, thus social networks and broader community connections can act as the primary source of employment assistance and support. It is therefore critical to develop new strategies to effectively cultivate, expand, and leverage social connections to facilitate and improve employment outcomes for youth, young adults, and adults with IDD. To address this goal, research questions may include:

- a. *What strategies most effectively develop new social relationships that can be tapped for employment?*
- b. *How do support professionals more effectively engage the broader community to facilitate and engage natural or other community members and resources to support employment?*
- c. *What are the most critical practices nonprofessionals need and how do they acquire these skills to support people with IDD that lack formal supports to obtain employment?*

5. *Develop and deploy consistent IDD and employment-related measures and data collection processes across federal agencies, programs, and surveys.*

At present, a major limitation to what is known about the employment and the economic status of people with IDD across the nation is the inconsistent, incongruent, and at times, nonexistent data available about this population across all aspects of the federal government. To ensure key decision makers, advocates, and researchers have accurate information about federal policies and programs, it is critical that existing programs of data collection and research are aligned and include people with IDD. In federal employment and economic assistance programs where out-

come data are not collected, expanding data collection processes to identify people with IDD and measure service users outcomes using common definitions and metrics would provide a clearer picture of program effectiveness for this population. A key part of this recommendation is requiring that states collect and report on employment participation using common variables for individuals supported by Medicaid HCBS funds, vocational rehabilitation services, education, and workforce development services. Additionally, federal survey programs such as the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's National Health Interview Survey lack a clear identification of people with IDD, thus limiting the applicability of the result and severely limiting the utility of the program to facilitate more informed decision making.

6. *Research to effectively build and scale-up community-level business engagement strategies that lead to successful career tracks.*

The business community is a vital partner to realize improvements in the employment situation for people with IDD; and as a field, there is an ongoing need to understand the demand side of the employment equation. Through business engagement strategies, valuable conduits can be developed to connect people with IDD to quality jobs. At the same time, such strategies can provide support professionals with an understanding about the business needs, allowing them to better support the business community. There is a present day need to better understand how to most effectively build and expand such strategies. The passage of WIOA highlights this need by emphasizing the importance of addressing business engagement strategies that respond to sector-specific skills gaps and labor shortages in local and regional communities. The WIOA explicitly requires the workforce development systems to plan and align its strategies to respond to local business conditions. Such initiatives must be accessible to people with IDD. To advance this goal, research questions may include:

- a. *What support professional practices lead to effective and sustainable partnerships with businesses?*
- b. *What are critical components to effectively scale-up business engagement strategies that lead to careers for people with IDD?*

- c. *What are effective ways to include and support people with IDD in business and sector-based initiatives?*
7. *Fund and implement a longitudinal data system that follows a cohort of people with IDD over their lifespan, within and outside of the public service systems, capturing an array of quality of life outcomes that include and extend beyond education, employment, economics, self-determination, community integration, health, and social connectedness and inclusion.*

At present, there is no national longitudinal data collected about people with IDD over the lifespan. As a result, it is unknown how employment affects this population over time and how life experiences compare to people who are unemployed or underemployed. As such, the final national goal seeks to expand what is known about the life trajectories of people with IDD. This ambitious goal cuts across many life domains and seeks to provide a comprehensive picture of individuals with IDD living in the United States. Rather than focus on employment alone, a more nuanced and holistic picture is sought by gaining a longitudinal understanding of how it relates to other critical aspects of life. Such a lifelong and comprehensive understanding of people with IDD will allow policy makers, practitioners, and researchers to more fully understand the role of employment in the broader life context.

Implications

The national goals for employment and economic self-sufficiency for people with IDD are meant to provide a clear vision for the future of policy, practice, and research. Purposely infused in these goals is the belief that all people with IDD bring unique strengths and capacities to the general workforce and all those who want to work, develop in careers, and become financially independent are capable, with or without supports, regardless of the intensity of their support needs. To improve the employment situation for people with IDD this belief must also be woven into the fabric of the formal systems and informal support networks.

If achieved, the goals presented will provide the field with a mix of new knowledge about the relationship between employment and other individual, system, and community factors; a suite of interventions that span practice to technolog-

ical; a greater capacity to scale-up effective strategies within and outside of formal systems; and focused strategies to improve system performance. To achieve these goals, a strong and enduring commitment is needed. Personal, professional, and financial investments must be made; as must strong advocacy efforts of people with IDD, their family members, professionals, and other allies. Together, it is possible to make employment and economic self-sufficiency a reality and realize these national goals.

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